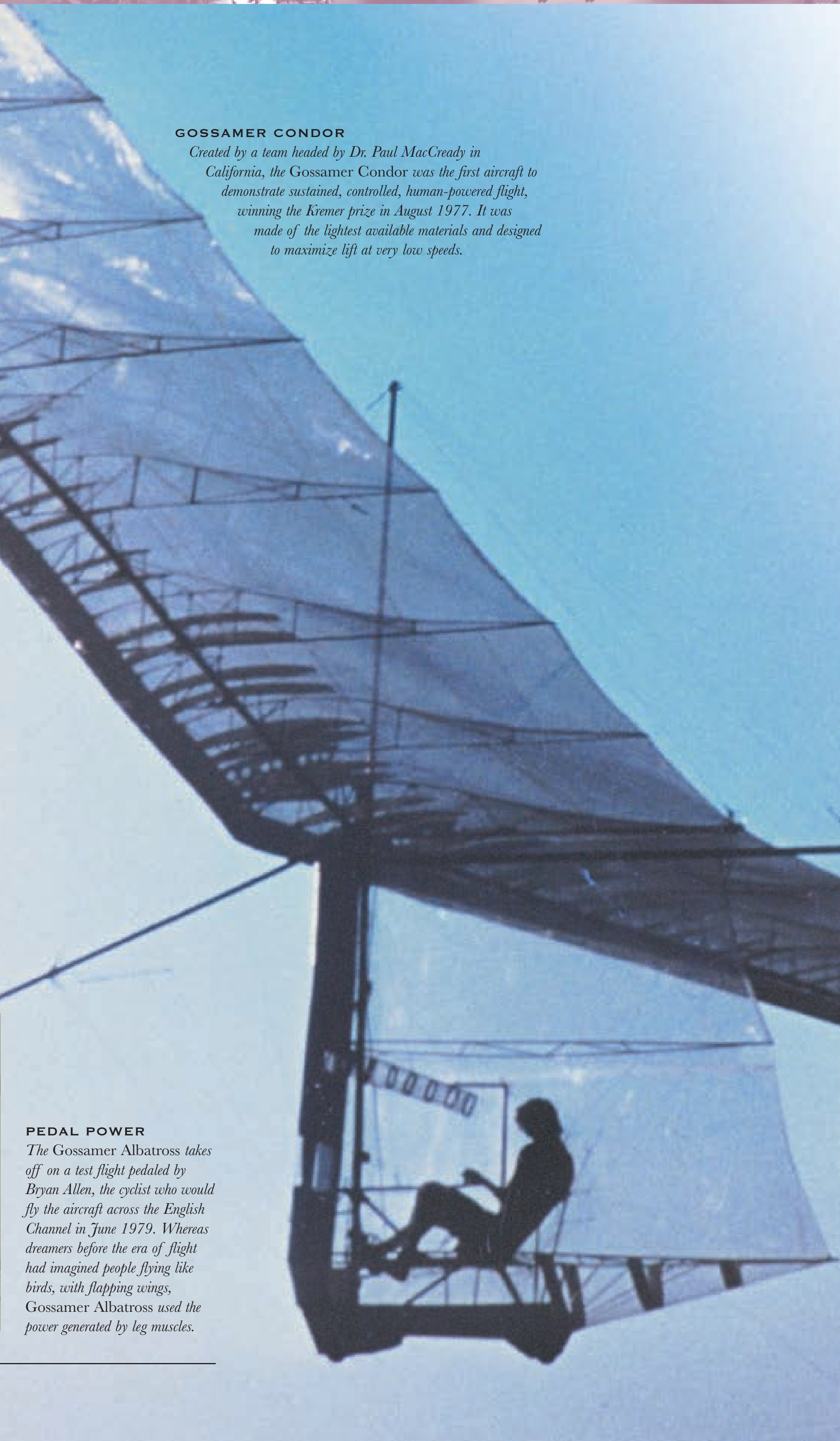

GOSSAMER CONDOR

Created by a team headed by Dr. Paul MacCready in California, the Gossamer Condor *was the first aircraft to demonstrate sustained, controlled, human-powered flight, winning the Kremer prize in August 1977. It was made of the lightest available materials and designed to maximize lift at very low speeds.*

The worst moment came on the last night of the flight, when the engine stopped over the Pacific north of Mexico and they glided silently in the darkness for five minutes before regaining power. The following morning they reached Edwards AFB, 9 days, 3 minutes, and 44 seconds after taking off, completing a journey of 26,178 miles (42,120km). There were 106lb (48kg) of fuel left in the tanks.

Return of the pioneers

In the era of wide-body jets and fly-by-wire fighters, the *Voyager* flight was a project that harkened back to more romantic times, when pioneering individuals could produce innovative designs in a small workshop or make record-breaking flights in private planes. It showed that the spirit of the Wright brothers and Lindbergh was still very much alive – that there were still gifted and courageous experimenters who regarded flight as an adventure and sought out areas to explore that had been neglected in the onward march of the big battalions.

PEDAL POWER

The Gossamer Albatross *takes off on a test flight pedaled by Bryan Allen, the cyclist who would fly the aircraft across the English Channel in June 1979. Whereas dreamers before the era of flight had imagined people flying like birds, with flapping wings,* Gossamer Albatross *used the power generated by leg muscles.*